

“The **greatness of America** lies not in being **more enlightened** than any other nation, but rather in her ability to **repair her faults.**”

ALEXIS DE TOCQUEVILLE, FRENCH HISTORIAN, IN *DEMOCRACY IN AMERICA*, 1835

Cotton-based economy

On the Southern plantations, slaves cultivated sugar, rice, and tobacco and many acquired the skills necessary to keep a plantation operating. It was cotton, however, that dominated, and as production soared, slaves worked ever longer hours in the cotton fields. Cotton was the key American export, accounting for more than half of all goods exported through 1850. In 1860, Britain took the bulk of American cotton exports—nearly 75 percent of the cotton Britain used came from the United States. But the labor of slaves and production of cotton were not merely matters for the South. The entire domestic economy was bound up in them. Western food fed the slave population, which grew and tended the cotton, while early Northeastern textile and shoe factories sold their output to the South for enslavers to provide for their slaves. Firms in New York City and New England benefited by providing financial backing and insurance for the burgeoning cotton and slave trades.